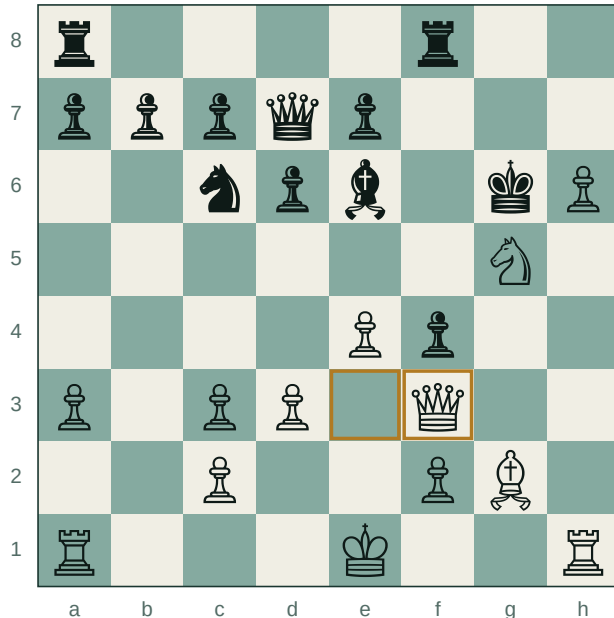


Trapping a piece: Black, move 18

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 18.Qf3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18...Bg4 19. Qh3 Bxh3 20. Bxh3 Qe8

18...Bg4 The bishop moves from e6 to g4. Recorded reply: **19.Qh3**.

19...Bxh3 The bishop captures the queen on h3. Recorded reply: **20.Bxh3**.

20...Qe8 The queen moves from d7 to e8.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 28 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -1 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: knight on g5 and rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.